

find every—and we mean every—subject that you can think of, from psychology to zoology to business administration to philosophy. Some degrees are more popular than others, and will figure more often. You can also get Bachelors and Masters Degrees, PhDs, and more types of degrees and diplomas than you knew existed!

Next, **'where'** can you study? From the comfort of your home, of course! (Or from the comfort of your office, if you don't tell your boss about it, and if you have enough time on your hands.) You can also study while travelling, if you're pressed for time.

'Why' online? There are various reasons as to why one would need to take up an online educational programme. First of all, there's the 'study abroad' factor: if you cannot afford to go to the US or Canada or Australia or the UK, and want a 'foreign' degree, getting it online is your best bet.

Then, there's the time factor: you can't take a sabbatical from work, and you need to study while working. Or, you may have completed part of your college, left mid-way to start working, and now feel it's time to complete your education—your work experience and previous college education will also fetch you credits. And then, there's the prospect of enhancing your work skills, and if your lucky enough, your employer is willing to pay for a certification—so you sign up for an online course, and at the same time continue working. Some employers will even pay your course fees for a full-fledged degree programme, including an MBA.

'When' do you enrol? Most online universities (including the online departments of regular universities), allow students to enrol at several points of time throughout the year. While some colleges open admissions thrice in a year, others may do so as often as six times. And, as you've probably guessed, online means the time shouldn't matter—ideally, you should be able to enrol on any given day! However, there are a few restrictions due to which institutions allow you to enrol only at specific times of the year.

'How' does it work? It's simple—course material is brought to you via the Web, e-mail, video-conferencing, and also by written material delivered to your doorstep. Generally, you study at your own pace, but there's usually a time-frame within which you must complete your degree requirements.

Examinations are usually open-book and online. Admission is given on the basis of your prior educational qualifications and work experience—your physical transcripts are formally evaluated by the institution, or by an agency appointed by the institution. Many institutions require you to be employed in order to take courses online.

Finally, the **'who'**: *Digit* cannot, naturally, make any claims for the universities or institutions mentioned, because none of us have obtained degrees from any of these places. Read on for a sampler of some of the places from where you can obtain a degree.

Remember, before beginning an online degree programme, it's important to ask about the institution's and the degree's accreditations. This is because you need to be sure that you will be furnished with a degree that is recognised by

employers and universities after the completion of your course. Accreditation can be done by national and regional organisations, however, national accreditation is more prestigious.

Here's are some aspects you should consider before deciding to get a degree online:

- ❑ Online classes require as much work as offline ones. Do you have the time? Don't be under the impression that just because you don't have to attend classes, you'll require less time.
- ❑ Will you be motivated enough to study without professors and classes to urge you on? And will you have the discipline to do it?
- ❑ What about your finances? Will the degree be worth it, in terms of career advancement and/or the possibility of further studies?
- ❑ Whether videoconferencing is there or not, how important is face-to-face contact with a professor to you?

If you really need that degree, and in your present circumstances, cannot attend a 'real' university, consider yourself lucky if you answered positively to all the above. Here

are some institutions we've picked:

American Public University System (www.apus.edu)

The American Public University System is a private higher-education community comprising two online learning institutions: American Public University and American Military University.

Serving over 12,000 students worldwide, APUS welcomes international students. There are over 150 programmes, and you can get an Associate Degree, a Bachelor's Degree, or even a Masters Degree. There are also some Certificate Programmes available.

APUS is accredited by the Distance Education And Training Council. To get into a Bachelor's program, APUS requires the online application and orientation be completed, followed by sending in high-school transcripts or diplomas. APUS will review previous college coursework for potential credit towards the degree.

Bachelors programmes range from Aerospace to Business Administration to Management to Marketing to Philosophy. In fact, American Public University has one of the widest ranges of programmes available.

Fees are \$750 per 3-credit course, and the Bachelors degree requires 120 credit hours. That works out to approximately Rs 13 lakh. For more information see <http://snipurl.com/enhance1>.

Washington State University (<http://distance.wsu.edu>)

Washington State University is accredited by the Commission on Colleges of the Northwest Association of Schools and Colleges. It is also a member of the National University Continuing Education Association, and is listed in the official publications of the US Office of Education and the State

AMU has a very wide variety of courses available